Happenings in Handmade

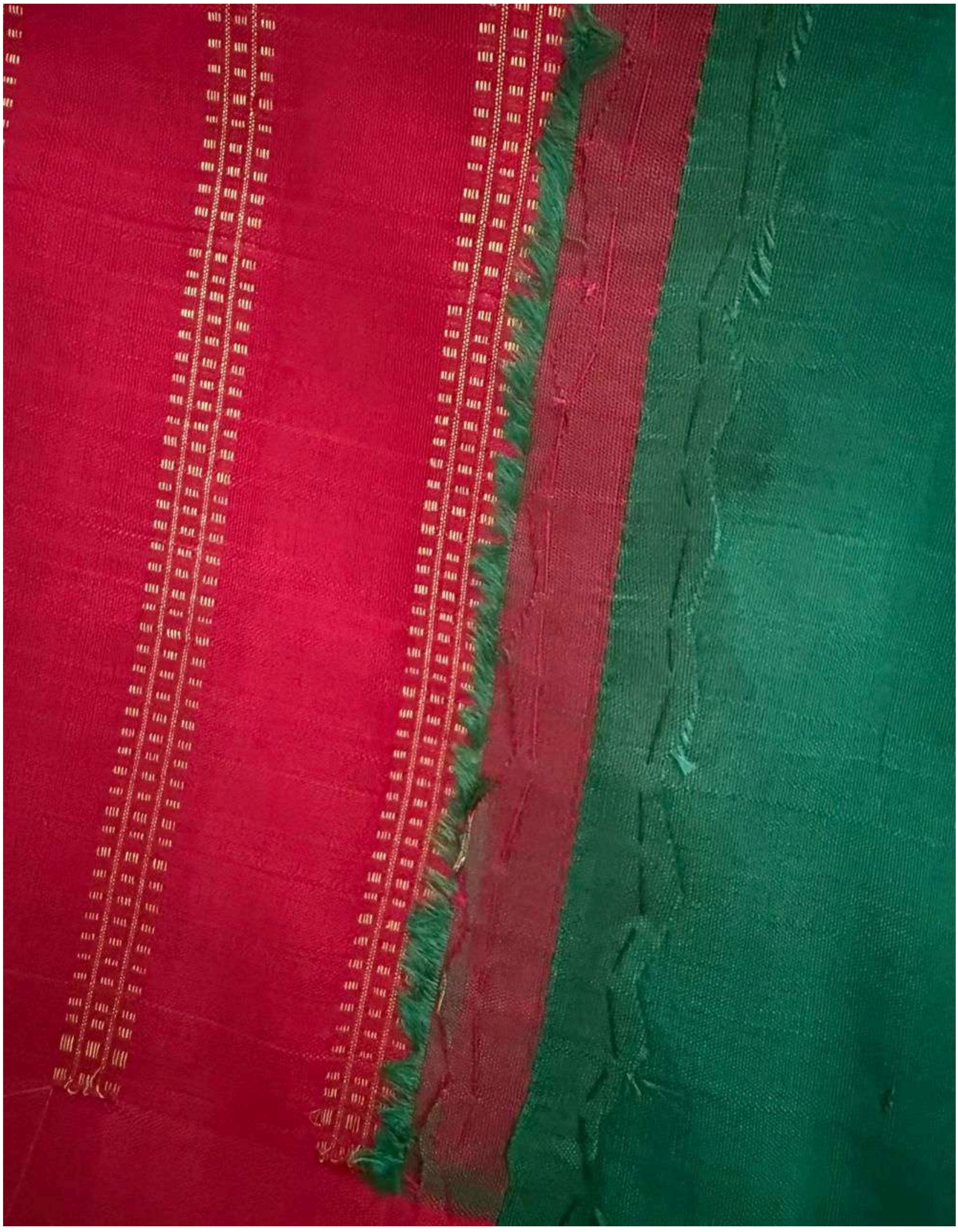
A CCI initiative

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THE MAGICAL ART OF MENDING FABRIC



‘A rafugar is a healer of damaged cloth’, said the late textile artist and researcher, Priya Ravish Mehra, referring to the name by which the descendants of expert darners, who migrated to India from Samarkand and Iran during the Mughal reign, are known. She believed that the desire to mend springs from a nostalgic or emotional association with a much-loved cloth, and is akin to recovering old relationships.

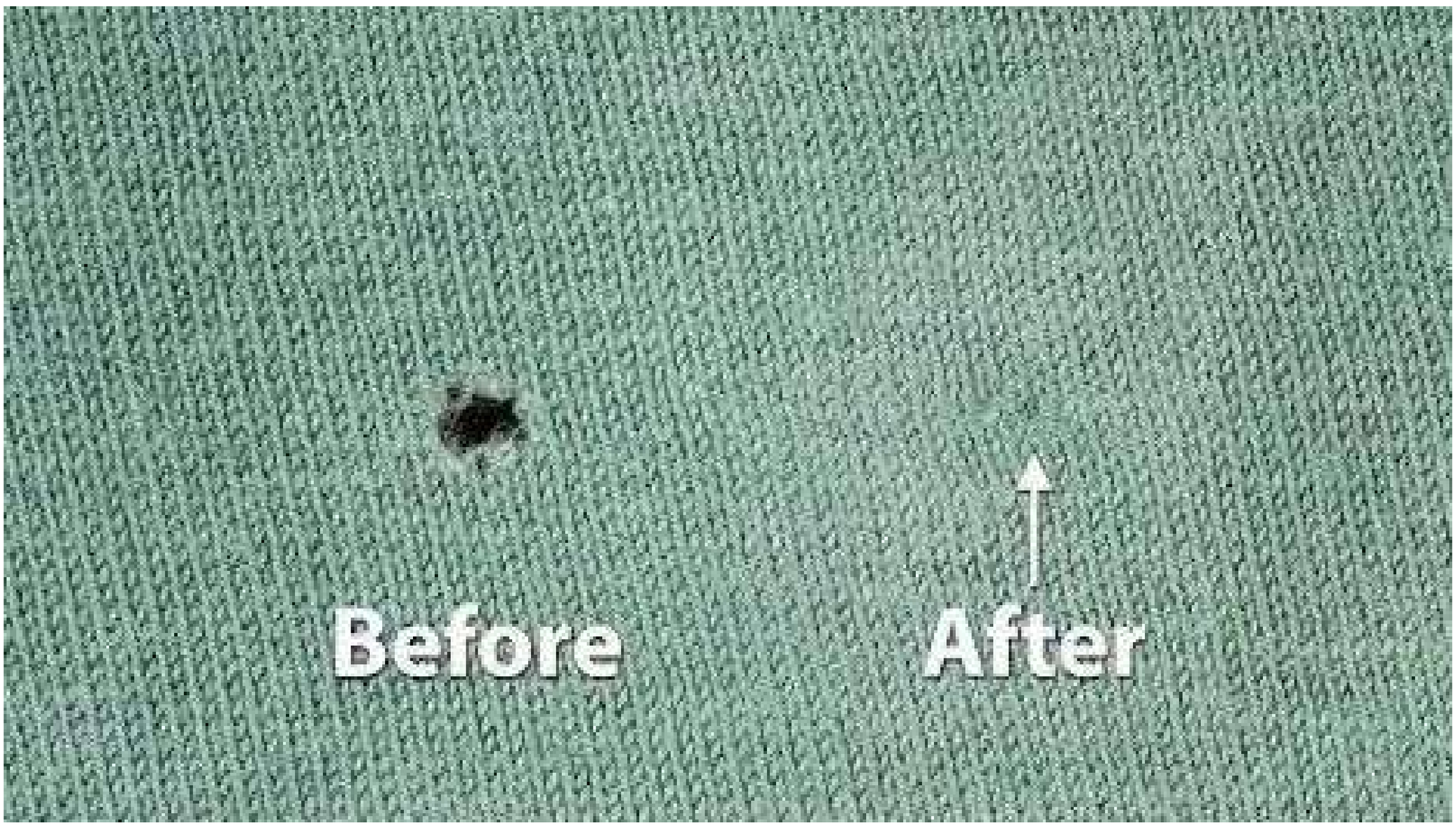


The reverse of the ripped pallu
of an old silk saree...



... restored to perfection

Before mass manufacture
made it easier to purchase new
fabric, and soon entirely new
clothes, mending fabric
was an economic necessity
in many parts of the world.
It was cheaper to mend an old
garment than to buy
or create a new one.
Invisible darning became
a prized skill.

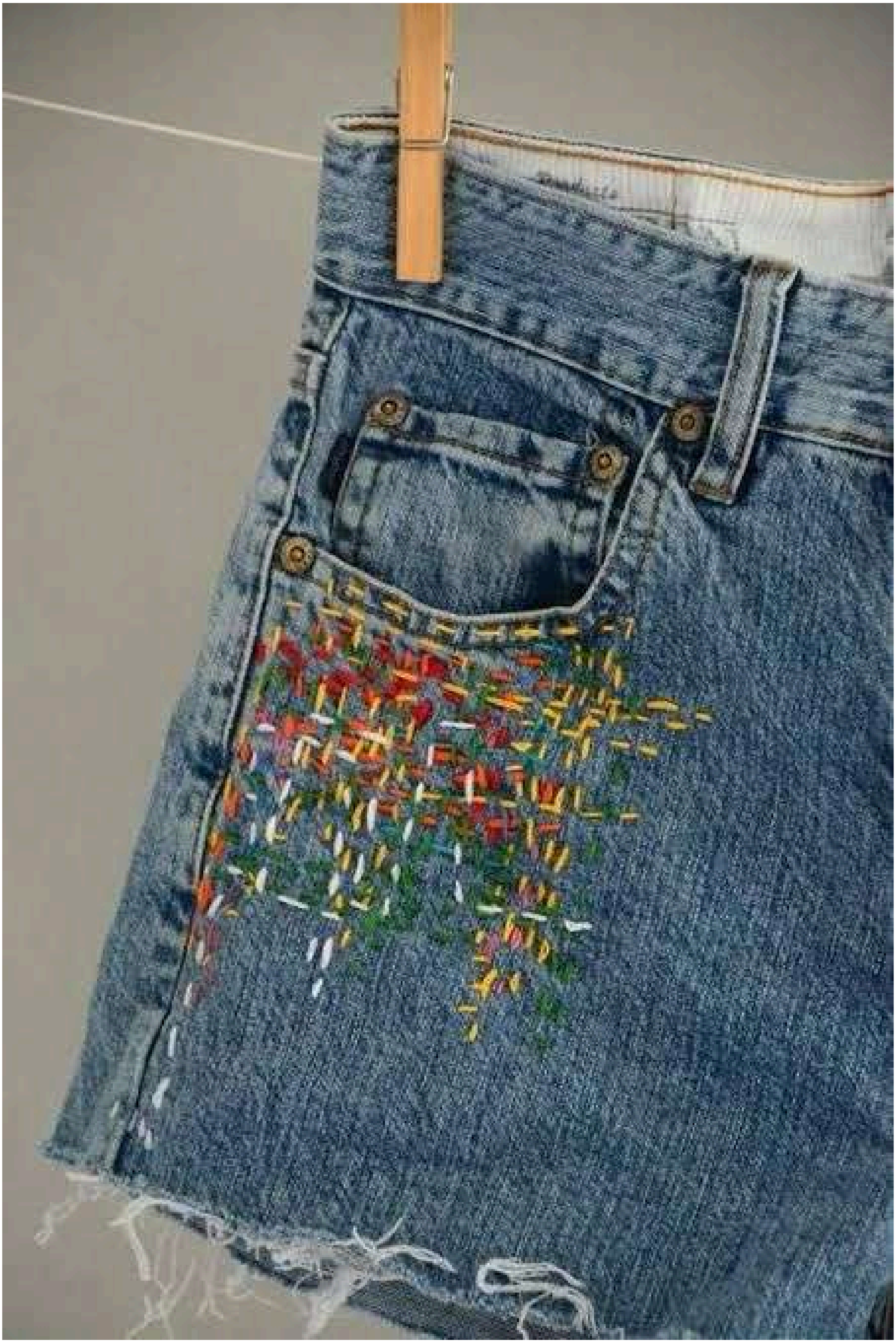

Before
After

In time, darning began to employ adornment, by way of motifs or patches, to conceal flaws with colourful flair.



In Japan, the old visible darning method of Sashiko, using simple running stitches, was born out of the same practical need and has now seen a revival.

Japanese Boro mending is another traditional repair technique that uses Sashiko stitching to patch worn clothing and textiles.







A Boro sleeping mat, created from several old fabrics, speaks visibly of a storied family history

This reminds one of the origins of our own Kantha, a word of Sanskrit origin meaning ‘rags’ – same as Boro, oceans away! Women used soft old saris to stitch everyday quilts and infant swaddling, named simply ‘Kantha’, also with a running stitch. Sometimes the process would take several years, with the work of sewing a Kantha passing from one generation to the next.



An elaborate vintage Kantha blanket

While visible darning has its merits and quirky charm, invisible mending, Rafugari, is indisputably the pinnacle of fine darning.

Yet, like all handmade arts it is in danger of disappearing. The younger generation of artisan families doesn't have the requisite patience or interest. Meanwhile, new and affordable fashions beckon customers from every street corner.

However, a parallel movement in our eco-endangered times urges one to repair, re-use, recycle. No better time for us to track down our city's best Rafugars, who are equally at risk in this environment. By giving them our custom, we could revive and preserve a heritage craft...and 'heal' to perfection many damaged heirloom textiles that we have been loath to give away.

